

Some Instances of NP-deletion in French

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1. Constraints on NP-deletion.

French has familiar instances of NP-deletion. Alongside (1) and (2), it allows NP-deletion in (3) and (4):

- (1) Trois linguistes ont téléphoné. ('three linguists have telephoned')
- (2) Plusieurs linguistes ont téléphoné. ('several...')
- (3) Trois ont téléphoné.
- (4) Plusieurs ont téléphoné.

Yet NP-deletion is excluded with the following:

- (5) Des linguistes ont téléphoné.
- (6) *Des ont téléphoné.

As opposed to *trois* and *plusieurs*, the complex determiner *des* does not allow NP-deletion in (6). Nor is NP-deletion allowed with the definite article *les* in:

- (7) Les linguistes ont téléphoné.
- (8) *Les ont téléphoné.

Although *des* in (5) can be translated as *some*, it is actually composed of *de+les* ('of+the'), with the *l-* of *les* deleting after *de* in a way that is not limited to determiner-like occurrences of *des*, as can be seen by considering the following pair:¹

- (9) Jean a parlé de ces linguistes. ('J has spoken of those/these linguists')
- (10) *Jean a parlé de les linguistes.

If the demonstrative *ces* in (9) is replaced by *les*, the result is sharply unacceptable.

The corresponding acceptable version must have *des* in place of **de les*:

- (11) Jean a parlé des linguistes.

Though not a determiner in (11), *des* there reflects the same morphosyntactic property of French seen with *des* in (5).

2. Stranding *des*.

Taking *des* in (5) and (11) to be 'de+les' readily leads to the thought that the deviance of (6) reduces to that of (8), via the more general observation that NP-deletion in French cannot ever strand a definite article. However, although dealing with (6) and (8) in a (partly) comparable way is surely on the right track, the parallelism is not perfect, as can be seen if we add a relative clause:

- (12) ??(?)Des qui sont bons se trouvent par là. ('des that are good...')
- (13) *Les qui sont bons se trouvent par là. ('the that are good...')

¹The *l-* of *les* does not delete when *les* is an object clitic:

- i) Tu as promis de les lire. ('you have promised *de les* to-read')
- ii) *Tu as promis des lire.

Speakers find (13) even worse than the rather poor (12).²

This weak contrast becomes more salient if we switch to object position:

(14) Jean en a des qui sont bons. ('J of-them has *des*/some that are good')

(15) *Jean a les qui sont bons.

In (very) colloquial French, (14) is fine,³ whereas (15) is not found in any register or regional French that we know of.

Since neither (12) nor (14) is part of standard French, we will need to understand, on the one hand, why the parallelism between (6) and (8) does hold in standard French, and, yet on the other hand, why that parallelism breaks down at least in part in (very) colloquial French.

As for the status of NP-deletion in (14), it may be that it is disallowed in standard French for the same reason as (15). If so, the colloquial French that finds (12) (very) marginal and (14) fine might, at the relevant point in the derivation, be taking *des* to be (closer to) 'de+es', rather than 'de+les'. With regard to (15) itself, note the following contrast:

(16) Ils ont pris les rouges. ('they have taken the reds')

(17) *Ils ont pris les qui sont rouges. ('they have taken the which are red')

Although NP-deletion stranding a definite article is not admissible in the immediate context of a relative clause, it is fine in the immediate context of an adjective. This may be due to the deleted NP actually being post-adjectival in (16),⁴ combined with the fact that a NP cannot be post-relative-clause. In other words, it may be that NP-deletion in French cannot take place if the NP is immediately preceded by the definite article.⁵

A type of French sentence close to (17), yet fully acceptable, is:

(18) Ils ont pris ceux/celles qui sont rouges. ('they have taken those(m.)/those(f.) that are red')

with *ceux* or *celles* instead of *les*. This *ceux/celles* is almost certainly to be analyzed as 'ce+eux/elles' ('this/that+them'), with *ce* here a non-agreeing demonstrative (as discussed in Kayne (2010a)) and *eux/elles* a non-clitic third-person pronoun. Moreover, (18) itself is almost certainly to be analyzed as containing, in addition to *ceux/celles*, a deleted NP, as in Pollock (2024, chapter 7). The reason that NP-deletion in (18) is

²Some speakers make a further distinction between marginal examples like the first of these and (i), sometimes considered worse, with a preposition:

(i) ???On a opté pour des qui sont rouges. ('We opted for de+(l)es which are red')

³Cf. Spitzer (1928).

⁴This presupposes that in *les rouges* the deleted noun is post-adjectival despite the ill-formedness of **les rouges livres*. On this and much else, see Valois (1991) and Cinque (1994; 2010). Why Spanish and Catalan, but not Italian or French, do allow definite article + relative clause remains to be understood.

⁵Unless that definite article can, thinking of Postal (1966) and Cardinaletti & Starke (1999), find itself in a clitic position. It remains to be understood why Romance languages have object clitics that look like definite articles, but apparently no object clitics that look like demonstratives (the Vaudois *ça* discussed by Bürge (1998) matches object clitic behavior only in part).

acceptable, and in (17) not, may just be that (18) has no definite article, and/or that the *eux/elles* of (18) separates the site of NP-deletion from *ce*.⁶

It is to be noted that (18) contrasts sharply with the totally unacceptable (19):

(19) *Ils ont pris ces qui sont rouges. ('they've taken those that are red')

in which the deleted NP immediately follows *ces*, parallel to the lexical NP doing so in the acceptable:

(20) Ils ont pris ces bonbons qui sont rouges. ('they've taken those sweets ...')

The deviance of (19) calls out for a common account with that of (17), which suggests that *ces* in (19) is definite in a way parallel to *les* in (17). As a possible execution of this idea, we can say that *ces* in fact hosts a non lexical *le* (= LE, with capitals indicating silence), as in:

(21) *ce+L(E)+es*

and as is overtly the case in such languages as Hungarian ('*ez a ház*' = 'ce la maison' = 'that the house') or Romanian ('*omul acesta*' = 'homme-le ce' = 'man-the that').⁷

3. Plural vs. mass.

The plural *des* of (5) has mass noun counterparts in French:

(22) *Du vin se trouve sur la table.* ('*du* wine refl. finds on the table')

(23) *De la bière se trouve sur la table.* ('*de la* beer...')

In (23), feminine *de la* ('of the') is transparently parallel to the 'de+les' postulated for plural *des*. Masculine *du* in (22) has the same *d-*, but is otherwise fairly opaque, compared to the expected 'de+le', and in particular lacks any visible *l-*.⁸ Of particular interest is the fact that the mass noun counterparts of (the marginal) (12), repeated here:

(24) ??(?)*Des qui sont bons se trouvent par là.* ('*des* that are good...')

are not possible at all:

(25) **Du qui est très bon se trouve sur la table.* ('*du* which is very good...')

(26) **De la qui est très bonne se trouve sur la table.*

⁶For an approach grouping the *ce* of *ceux, celles* (and singular *celui, celle*), with the *ce* of free relatives – e.g. *J'aime ce qui est rouge* ('I like this that+*i* is red' = I like what is red) – with the *ce* of complex subordination cases like *Il se moque de *(ce) que les étudiants ne l'écoutent pas* ('he doesn't give a damn about this that his students don't listen to him' = he doesn't give a damn about his students not listening to him') and even with the *ce* of *par*(ce) que* ('by this that' = because), see Pollock (2024, chapter 7).

⁷Cf. Giusti (1994); on Hungarian, cf. É. Kiss (2002, 163). The rapprochement between *les* and *ces* under discussion is strengthened by the acceptability of:

i) *Ils ont pris ces rouges(-ci) et je prendrai ces verts(-là)* ('they've taken these (here) red and I'll take these (there) green')
parallel to:

ii) *Ils ont pris les rouges et je prendrai les verts.*

⁸The /u/ of *du* is often described (e.g. in the entry *de* in *Dictionnaire historique de la langue française*, Le Robert, 2010), as the velarization of /l/ in a historical process of the type *de+le* > *de+u* > *du*. If so /u/ is to /l/ in *du* what /o/ is to /l/ in *chevaux* vs. *cheval*.

The mass noun counterparts of plural *des livres* ('des books') can also readily occur in object position:

(27) Ils ont acheté du vin. ('they have bought *du* wine')

(28) Ils ont acheté de la bière.

Here, too, there is a sharp contrast with plural *des*. The (colloquial) French that allows (14), repeated here:

(29) Jean en a des qui sont bons. ('J of-them has *des*/some that are good')

excludes both of the following:⁹

(30) *Ils en ont du qui est très bon. ('they of-it have *du* which...')

(31) *Ils en ont de la qui est très bonne.

We would like to suggest that this plural vs. mass contrast is due to the necessary presence in (29) of a silent NP corresponding to *quantités* ('quantities'), as shown in (33), the non lexical counterpart of the fine (32):

(32) Jean en a des quantités qui sont bons.

(33) J en a des QUANTITÉS qui sont bons.

On this view, (30)/(31) are bad, with *du/de la*, because they don't lend themselves to a comparable analysis, as shown by the sharp unacceptability of (34) and (35):

(34) *Ils en ont du quantité qui est très bon(ne).

(35) *Ils en ont de la quantité qui est très bon(ne).

The necessary presence of silent QUANTITIES in (29) will also play a role in the account of the following contrast:

(36) Je parle des livres qui sont bons. ('I speak *des* books that are good')

(37) *Je parle des qui sont bons.

Although (36) resembles the lexical counterpart of (29), namely:

(38) Jean a des livres qui sont bons. ('J has *des* books...')

(37) is not possible. The reason is in part that in (36), but not in (38), there is a phrase *les livres qui sont bons* which is the object of the preposition *de*. The other principal part of the account is that that fact about (36) leaves no room for silent QUANTITIES to appear there, in a way related to the impossibility of overt *quantités* in:¹⁰

(39) *Je parle des quantités qui sont bons.

4. *Quantités* and QUANTITIES

The negative counterpart of a French sentence containing an object of the form *des N* such as (38) will normally have *des* giving way to *de*, as in:

(40) Jean n'a pas de livres qui sont/soient bons. ('J neg has not of books that are(indic./subjunc.) good')

⁹For some, the masculine version is fractionally less bad than the feminine version, in a way that might be related to the presence of a pronounced /- in the feminine.

¹⁰In addition to the fact that silent/non-lexical livres in *Je parle des LIVRES qui sont bons* is excluded in standard French for the same reason as *J'ai lu ces/les LIVRES qui sont bons*, as described above. We leave open questions concerning the indefinite article, as well as questions concerning gender agreement with silent/deleted nouns, on which, cf. the contrasting views of Gouet (1976) and Morin (1977) and for recent discussion Pereira (2024).

Of interest is the fact that this does not carry over to (32), whose negative counterpart might be expected to be:

(41) *Jean n'en a pas de quantités qui sont/soient bons.

But this sentence is unacceptable. Of special interest now is the fact that the deviance of (41) feeds directly into an account of the sharp deviance of the negative counterpart of (29). (29) itself is repeated here:

(42) Jean en a des qui sont bons. ('J of-them has *des*/some that are good')

Its negative counterpart is:

(43) *Jean n'en a pas de qui sont/soient bons.

The reason for the sharp deviance of (43) is that silent QUANTITIES is no more possible in (43) than overt *quantités* is in (41).

We can note in addition that putting *des* back in (43) leads to improvement:¹¹

(44) ?J'en ai des qui sont bons mais j'en ai pas des qui sont excellents. ('I of-them have *des* that are good but I of-them have not *des* that are excellent')

correlating strikingly with the improvement seen in (41) if *de* is replaced by *des*:

(45) ?J'en ai des quantités qui sont bons mais j'en ai pas des quantités qui sont excellents.

That *des quantités* in (45) is better than *de quantités* in (41) is matched by the fact that *des QUANTITIES* in (44) is better than *de QUANTITIES* in (43).

5. An apparent challenge to QUANTITIES.

A fully lexical counterpart to (42) would be:

(46) Jean a des quantités de livres qui sont bons. ('J has *des* quantities of books that are good')

in which *quantités* is related to *livres*. To some extent, plural *livres* can be replaced by a mass noun, e.g.:

(47) ?Pierre a des quantités de fric qui ne lui appartient pas sur son compte en banque. ('P has *des* quantities of cash that neg. him(dat.) belongs not on his account in bank')

But the counterpart to (47) in which, parallel to (42), we would have both *en* and silent QUANTITIES, along with a silent mass noun, is not possible:

(48) *Pierre en a des qui ne lui appartient pas sur son compte en banque.

If we think of (42) as:

(49) J en a des QUANTITÉS DE LIVRES qui sont bons

then (48) will be excluded if the following holds:

(50) Plural QUANTITIES is possible in such cases only if its associated N(P) is also plural.

¹¹In these examples *ne* is omitted for reasons of stylistic coherence. They are somewhat awkward in that colloquial register of French, presumably for the same reason that (i) is a bit dubious compared to (ii). (i) would be perfect in the context of (iii) where *des* contrasts with *un*.

(i) ?J'ai pas des amis. ('I have not *des* friends')

(ii) J'ai pas d'amis. ('I have not of friends')

(iii) J'ai pas des amis, j'en ai un. ('I have not *des* friends, I of-them have one')

We note in passing that in addition to plural *des quantités*/QUANTITIES as in a number of the above examples, French also allows singular bare *quantité*:

(51) Ils ont acheté quantité de livres. ('they have bought quantity of books')
But in this case, as opposed to (32) and (45), *en* is not allowed:¹²

(52) *Ils en ont acheté quantité.

This bare singular *quantité* shares with the plural *quantités* that occurs in *des quantités* the property that it cannot be deleted without its associated N(P) also being deleted:

(53) Ils ont acheté *(quantité) de livres.

(54) Ils ont acheté des *(quantités) de livres.

Possibly, the restriction illustrated in (53)/(54) is telling us that subdeletion of this sort in the presence of *de/of* is never possible, in apparent contrast to the subextraction seen in:

(55) Combien ont-ils acheté de livres? ('how-many have they bought of books')
with the strength of that contrast diminished if Kayne (2002, sect. 2.6) was right to take (55) to involve remnant movement, rather than subextraction of *combien*.

6. Missing determiners.

We should note in addition that standard French has a quite straightforward counterpart of (42) that is seen in:

(56) Jean en a qui sont bons. ('J of-them has that are good')

(57) J'en ai qui sont bons, mais je n'en ai pas qui sont excellents.
in both of which NP-deletion examples *des* itself no longer appears.¹³

This is, however, not at all possible in the case of (12), repeated here:

(58) ??(?)Des qui sont bons se trouvent par là. ('des that are good...')

as shown by:

(59) *Qui sont bons se trouvent par là. ('that are good...')

as well as by the fact that the marginal status of:

(60) ??(?) Des qui sont bons, j'en ai. ('des that are good, I of-them have')

(61) ??(?) Des qui soient excellents, j'en ai pas. ('des that are excellent, I of-them have not')

turns to sharply unacceptable if *des* is not present:

(62) *Qui sont bons, j'en ai.

(63) *Qui sont/soient excellents, j'en ai pas.

Similarly, again in contrast to the admissible absence of *des* in (56)/(57), absence of *des* is not at all possible in the case of objects of a preposition, as shown by the following:

(64) *Jean pense à qui sont bons. ('J thinks of that are good')

(65) *Je ne serais pas contre qui seraient excellents ('I wouldn't be against that would be excellent')

¹²For unclear reasons. A similar fact holds for bare *nombre*:

i) Ils ont nombre de livres. ('they have number of books')

ii) *Ils en ont nombre.

¹³Cf. Kayne (1975, sect. 2.9).

which contrast in acceptability with the corresponding sentences in which *des* is present:

(66) ??(?)Je pense à des qui sont bons.

(67) ??(?)Je ne serais pas contre des qui seraient excellents.

7. The importance of clitic *en*.

The silent *des* of (56)/(57), in not being transposable to subject position or to prepositional object position, looks like it might be subject to a restriction of the ECP-type.¹⁴ However, since the status of the ECP is, in the current framework that denies primitive status to the notion of ‘government’, questionable, let us look at these facts in another way, one that emphasizes the presence in the acceptable (56)/(57) of the clitic *en* vs. the absence of *en* in the sharply unacceptable examples (59) and (62)-(65).

To do that, it will be convenient to look again at the mass noun counterparts of *des*, as in:

(68) Ils ont du vin qui vient d’Amérique. (‘they have of-the wine that comes from A.’)

(69) Ils ont de la bière qui vient d’Amérique. (‘...of-the beer...’)

The corresponding NP-deletion sentence is:

(70) Ils en ont qui vient d’Amérique. (‘they of-it have...’)

in which *en* appears¹⁵ and in which *du* (masc.) and *de la* (fem.) do not appear.

This non-appearance of *du/de la* in (70) is obligatory:

(71) *Ils en ont du qui vient d’Amérique.

(72) *Ils en ont de la qui vient d’Amérique.

which could be taken to suggest that *en* in (70) is a cliticized version of *du/de la*.

8. A speculative aside on *en* and antihomophony.

For *en* to plausibly be a cliticized version of *du/de la*, though, we will need an answer to the question why clitic *en* has nothing in common, phonologically speaking, with *du/de la*, and at the same time an answer to the question why this *en* is, to the contrary, phonologically identical to the preposition seen in:

(73) Ils arriveront en avril. (‘they will-arrive in April’)

On the assumption that preposition *en* and clitic *en* are both part of the functional part of the French lexicon, their phonological identity, will, given the antihomophony principle/heuristic of Kayne (2019; 2025),¹⁶ require that they be the same element. This requirement can actually be met if we take into account the following facts of French:¹⁷

¹⁴Cf. Longobardi (1994) and references cited there, as well as Kayne (1981); on silent determiners in Romance of the *des* type, cf. also Kayne (2008).

¹⁵Obligatorily - cf. Kayne (2022).

¹⁶Cf. also Johns (1992, 84), Embick (2003, 156) and Bobaljik (2012, 35).

Note that in isolation *en* and *an* (‘year’) are homophonous, yet differ phonologically in that the vowel of *an* can be denasalized, as in *année* (‘year’), but the vowel of *en* cannot be.

¹⁷Which hold for numerals greater than one. With ‘one’, *l’un d’eux* (‘the one of them’) is generally possible, while *un d’eux* (‘one of them’) is fully acceptable in subject position.

Why English allows *five of them* perfectly well in contrast to French remains to be understood, along with the fact that in this respect Spanish and Italian pattern with English.

(74) cinq de nos amis ('five of our friends')

(75) *cinq d'eux ('five of them')

(76) cinq d'entre eux ('five of/from among them')

If *nos amis* in (74) is replaced by (non-clitic) third-person pronoun *eux*, then *de* must give way to *d'entre* (= *de+entre*, with schwa deletion applying to the -e of *de* in a way consonant with general French phonology).

Assume now, thinking in part of the fact that one Italian counterpart of *entre* is just *tra*,¹⁸ that French *entre* is bimorphemic,¹⁹ i.e. = *en+tre*, so that *d'entre* in (76) = *de+en+tre*. In which case we could take the clitic *en* of the following:

(77) Ils en ont lu cinq. ('they *en* have read five')

to be 'DE en TRE', with both the *de* and the *tre* parts of *d'entre* silent. If so, then clitic *en* and preposition *en* are in fact the same element.

To be noted is the fact that although (77) readily occurs as a follow-up to a sentence like:

(78) Vous avez lu quatre livres. ('you have read four books')

none of the pieces of 'DE en TRE' in (77) is, from our perspective, pronoun-like; consequently (77) must also contain a silent pronoun-like N (that may move along with 'DE en TRE').

Let us note further that although one might wonder at the cliticization of something as 'big' as 'DE en TRE', the cliticization of the 'en TRE' part is actually visible in the Gallo dialect discussed by Chauveau (1984, 203), who gives:

(79) I s'ente taient mordus. ('they refl.+*entre* were bitten' = 'They had bitten each other')

(80) On s'ente lë passët. ('one refl.+*entre* it passed' = 'we were passing it back and forth to each other')

(It might in addition be the case that cliticization in (77) has just 'en TRE' moving, stranding silent DE.)

Challenges remain. For example, the *d'entre* of (76) appears to be limited to plurals, as opposed to mass nouns. Yet *en* is compatible with (silent) mass nouns, as seen in (70), and as indicated there by the singular verb within the relative clause. A possibility that comes to mind, then, is that the *en* of (70), rather than being 'DE en TRE' is just 'DE en', without the TRE part, but with *en* still the preposition.

A second challenge comes from the cooccurrence of *en* and *de* in the previously discussed (cf. (42)):

(81) Jean en a des qui sont bons. ('J of-them has *des* that are good')

¹⁸Another is *fra*, readily taken (cf. Maiden and Robustelli (2000, 175)) to be a perfect synonym of *tra*, which, by antisynonymy (cf. Kayne (2024, sect.4)) should be impossible. An alternative would be to take Italian *tra* to be 'FRA tra' and *fra* to be 'fra TRA', with both then akin to English *from among*.

¹⁹Cf. the virtually certain non-monomorphemic status of English *between*, with *be-* the same as that of *beside*, *before*, *below*, and *-tw-* that of *twin*, *two*, *twelve*, *twenty*; and similarly for *among*, whose *a-* is plausibly that of *atop*, *astride*, *aside*...; likewise the arguably at least bimorphemic status of *inter-*, whose *in-* is very likely that of *insert*, *incise*, *inhale*, *import*... and of the familiar preposition *in*. On the combination *d'entre* itself, cf. *from among*.

which we are now led to analyze as:

(82) ...DE en TRE a des...

with one silent DE and one pronounced one (that is part of *des*). The weight of this challenge is, however, lessened by the existence of sentences close to (81), but with two instances of pronounced *de*, e.g.:²⁰

(83) En a-t-elle des rouges, de fleurs? ('*en* has-*t*-she *des* reds, of flowers')

9. *Des* and *the ones*.

There is a sharp contrast in French between the (very) colloquial (42), repeated in essence here:

(84) J'en ai des qui sont bons. ('I of-them have *des* that are good')

and the following, which as far as we know exists in no register of French:

(85) *J'en ai des.

In addition (85) contrasts with:

(86) J'en ai des quantités. ('I of-them have *des* quantities')

Let us conjecture that the very strong deviance of (85) is to be seen in the same light (whose contours will need to be filled in) as the following fact from English:²¹

(87) I have the ones *(that you asked me for).

This linking would appear to be supported by certain properties of relative clause extraposition, with the relevant fact illustrated in English by:

(88) I bought the ones (*yesterday) that you had asked me for.

a fact that finds a parallel in French:

(89) J'en ai acheté quelques-uns hier qui sont très bons. ('I of-them have bought some-ones yesterday that are very good')

(90) *J'en ai acheté des hier qui sont très bons.

Although relative clause extraposition past *hier* ('yesterday') is possible when the determiner is *quelques-uns*, it is not possible, as shown by (90), when the determiner is *des*, much, it would seem, as in (88), with this point of similarity between French *des* and English *the ones* then providing support for the linkage of (85) to (87).

10. NP-deletion leaving nothing visible in object position.

Although French does not allow (85), it does allow:

(91) J'en ai. ('I of-the have')

From our perspective, *en* corresponds to the cliticization of a complex determiner; in addition, in (91) NP-deletion has taken place. Now English has a deleted/silent determiner with indefinite plurals and indefinite mass nouns:²²

(92) They're out looking for syntax books/beer.

Yet in this case English does not allow NP-deletion:²³

²⁰Example from Kayne (1975, sect. 2.9); for more detailed discussion, see Pollock (1998).

²¹On *ones* itself, cf. Kayne (2017).

²²Cf. Chomsky (1965, 107).

²³Cf. Taraldsen (2017, 372) on Spanish, Portuguese and Romanian.

As for:

i) They're eating.

discussion is beyond the scope of this paper.

(93) *They're out looking for.
which contrasts with:

(94) We've been looking for some for a while now.
The generalization may be that NP-deletion always requires the presence of a pronounced determiner (which would recall Lobeck (1995) on VP-deletion), with *en* counting as that determiner in (91).

11. Conclusion.

We have attempted in this paper to shed light on a number of constraints that hold of French NP-deletion. An important role is played by silent elements, one of which, a silent counterpart of French *quantités*, allows an understanding of a surprising asymmetry between plural and mass nouns. We have also been led to consider missing determiners, with the object clitic *en* playing, against the background of antihomophony, a key role.

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